affirmed its intention ‘to uphold democratic centralism and collective leadership, oppose the personality cult, promote democracy within the Party and among the people and strengthen the Party’s ties with the masses’. There is little doubt that these remarks were triggered by the denunciation of Stalin in the Soviet Union and indirectly warned against a similar cult of personality emerging in China. Mao would have seen this as a not-too-subtle bid to circumscribe his authority, and his subsequent policies may have been driven by that anxiety. It may be recalled that one of the issues in the eventual ideological split between the two communist allies – China and the Soviet Union – was precisely Mao’s disagreement with the denunciation of Stalin, who continued to be revered by him as an outstanding Marxist leader.

Among the serious errors ascribed to Mao are the Great Leap Forward between 1959 and 1962, which led to widespread famine and economic chaos. This was the period in which collectivization of agriculture took place on the Stalinist model, through the setting up of People’s Communes. In order to fast-track industrialization, ‘backyard furnaces’ were set up to smelt iron and make agricultural implements and other crude metal products. Mao also began to argue – erroneously, according to the Resolution – that the ‘principal contradiction’ in China was ‘the sharpening of the class struggle between the proletarian masses and the petty bourgeoisie which now occupied leadership positions even within the Party’. [3] This was a direct repudiation of the line taken by the Eighth Party Congress in September 1956, which said that the principal contradiction was no longer between the working class and the bourgeoisie but ‘between the demand of the people for rapid economic and cultural development and the existing state of our economy and culture which fell short of the needs of the people’. [4] The Resolution says that under Mao’s mistaken approach and his ‘Left errors’, the Party overlooked objective economic laws, laid down ‘excessive targets’ and stirred up a ‘communist wind’. [5]

This also coincided with the worsening of relations with the Soviet Union, which withdrew virtually all its experts from China and suspended its economic aid. It should be recalled that this was also the period when